AWS DevOps Engineer - Professional (DOP-C02) Study Timeline

Start: Tue, Oct 13, 2026 **Target exam date:** Thu, Dec 17, 2026 (book it now - buffer until Dec 22)

Duration: ~9.5 weeks **Suggested pace:** 1.5-2 hrs on weekdays, 3-4 hrs on weekends (~12-15 hrs/week)

Exam at a glance

Item	Detail
Questions	75 (65 scored + 10 unscored), multiple choice / multiple response
Time	180 minutes
Passing score	750 / 1000
Cost	300 USD (check for a 50% voucher if you hold another AWS cert)

Domain	Weight	Study weeks
1. SDLC Automation	22%	Weeks 1-2
2. Configuration Management & IaC	17%	Weeks 3-4
3. Resilient Cloud Solutions	15%	Week 5
4. Monitoring & Logging	15%	Week 6
5. Incident & Event Response	14%	Week 6-7
6. Security & Compliance	17%	Week 7
Practice exams & review	-	Weeks 8-9

Week 0 - Setup & Baseline (Oct 13 - Oct 18)

- Read the official DOP-C02 Exam Guide (list of in-scope / out-of-scope services)
- Book the exam for Dec 17 (Pearson VUE, test center or online)
- Create a dedicated AWS sandbox account + AWS Budgets alert ($10-20)
- Enroll in a main course (e.g., Stephane Maarek / Adrian Cantrill) and AWS Skill Builder
- Take the free official practice question set (Skill Builder) - record baseline score: ____
- Set up a notes file per domain in this folder

Week 1 - Domain 1: SDLC Automation, Part 1 (Oct 19 - Oct 25)

CI/CD building blocks

- CodeCommit - repos, triggers, notifications, branch protection via IAM, cross-account access
- CodeBuild - `buildspec.yml` phases, env variables, Parameter Store/Secrets Manager in builds, caching, VPC builds, reports
- CodeArtifact - domains, repos, upstreams, npm/pip/maven
- Amazon ECR - lifecycle policies, image scanning (basic vs enhanced/Inspector), cross-region/cross-account replication
- CodePipeline - stages, actions, manual approvals, artifacts in S3 + KMS, cross-region & cross-account pipelines, V2 triggers/variables
- Integrating GitHub / Bitbucket via CodeStar Connections (CodeConnections)
- CodeGuru Reviewer / Profiler (light)

Lab: Build a pipeline: GitHub -> CodeBuild (unit tests) -> manual approval -> deploy to S3/EC2.

Week 2 - Domain 1: SDLC Automation, Part 2 (Oct 26 - Nov 1)

Deployment strategies & testing

- CodeDeploy - `appspec.yml`, lifecycle hooks (EC2/On-prem, Lambda, ECS), deployment configs, rollbacks, alarms
- Deployment patterns - in-place, rolling, rolling with batch, immutable, blue/green, canary, linear, traffic splitting
- Elastic Beanstalk - deployment policies, `.ebextensions`, swap URLs, worker environments
- Lambda - versions, aliases, weighted aliases, SAM `DeploymentPreference`
- ECS/Fargate - rolling vs CodeDeploy blue/green, task definitions, circuit breaker
- EKS basics for CI/CD (light)
- Testing in pipelines - unit/integration/load/security testing stages
- AMI pipelines - EC2 Image Builder

Lab: CodeDeploy blue/green for ECS and canary for Lambda with automatic rollback on a CloudWatch alarm.

Checkpoint: Domain 1 practice questions (aim >= 70%).

Week 3 - Domain 2: Infrastructure as Code (Nov 2 - Nov 8)

- CloudFormation core - parameters, mappings, conditions, outputs, intrinsic functions, pseudo params
- Change sets, drift detection, stack policies, termination protection, `DeletionPolicy` / `UpdateReplacePolicy`
- Nested stacks vs cross-stack references (Exports/ImportValue)
- `cfn-init`, `cfn-signal`, `cfn-hup`, CreationPolicy, WaitCondition, UpdatePolicy (ASG rolling/replacing)
- Custom resources (Lambda-backed), macros, modules, Hooks, Registry
- Rollback triggers, failure troubleshooting (UPDATE_ROLLBACK_FAILED, etc.)
- StackSets - self-managed vs service-managed, Organizations integration, automatic deployment
- AWS CDK - constructs, `cdk synth/diff/deploy`, pipelines
- AWS SAM - templates, `sam build/deploy`, local testing

Lab: Deploy an ASG + ALB stack with `cfn-init`/`cfn-signal` and rolling update policy; deploy one StackSet across 2 regions.

Week 4 - Domain 2: Configuration Management & Multi-Account (Nov 9 - Nov 15)

- AWS Systems Manager - Run Command, State Manager, Patch Manager (baselines, maintenance windows), Inventory, Session Manager, Parameter Store, Automation documents, Distributor, Fleet Manager
- AWS AppConfig - feature flags, deployment strategies, validators

- AWS Organizations - OUs, SCPs, consolidated billing, delegated administrators
- AWS Control Tower - landing zone, guardrails/controls, Account Factory, Account Factory for Terraform (AFT), customizations
- AWS Service Catalog - portfolios, products, launch constraints, TagOptions
- AWS Config - rules (managed/custom), conformance packs, aggregators, remediation via SSM
- Tagging strategy, Tag policies, Resource Groups
- AWS Resource Access Manager (RAM)

Lab: Patch Manager with a maintenance window; Config rule with automatic SSM remediation.

Checkpoint: Domain 2 practice questions (aim >= 70%).

Week 5 - Domain 3: Resilient Cloud Solutions (Nov 16 - Nov 22)

- DR strategies - backup & restore, pilot light, warm standby, multi-site active/active; RTO vs RPO
- Auto Scaling - lifecycle hooks, warm pools, termination policies, scaling policies (target/step/scheduled/predictive), instance refresh
- ELB - ALB/NLB/GWLB, health checks, connection draining, cross-zone, sticky sessions
- Route 53 - routing policies (failover, weighted, latency, geolocation), health checks, ARC (Application Recovery Controller)
- Multi-region data - Aurora Global Database, DynamoDB Global Tables, RDS read replicas/Multi-AZ, S3 CRR/SRR
- AWS Backup - plans, vaults, cross-region/cross-account copies, Vault Lock
- AWS Elastic Disaster Recovery (DRS)
- Decoupling - SQS (DLQ, visibility timeout), SNS, Kinesis, Step Functions
- Caching - CloudFront, ElastiCache
- AWS Fault Injection Service (FIS), Resilience Hub

Lab: Route 53 failover between two regions + Aurora Global Database (or DynamoDB Global Table) failover.

Checkpoint: Domain 3 practice questions (aim >= 70%).

Week 6 - Domain 4: Monitoring & Logging (Nov 23 - Nov 29)

- CloudWatch Metrics - custom metrics, high-resolution, metric math, anomaly detection, dashboards (cross-account)
- CloudWatch Alarms - composite alarms, actions (EC2/ASG/SNS/SSM)
- CloudWatch Agent - memory/disk metrics, log collection, config in Parameter Store
- CloudWatch Logs - metric filters, subscription filters (Lambda/Kinesis/Firehose), Logs Insights, retention, export to S3, cross-account log aggregation
- CloudWatch Synthetics (canaries), RUM, Container Insights, Lambda Insights, Application Signals
- AWS X-Ray - tracing, sampling rules, daemon, service map; AWS Distro for OpenTelemetry
- CloudTrail - management/data/Insights events, organization trails, log file validation, CloudTrail Lake
- Centralized logging - S3 + Athena, OpenSearch, Kinesis Data Firehose
- VPC Flow Logs, ELB/S3 access logs

Lab: Centralize logs from 2 accounts into one S3 bucket via subscription filter + Firehose; query with Athena.

Week 7 - Domain 5: Incident & Event Response + Domain 6: Security & Compliance (Nov 30 - Dec 6)

Domain 5 (Mon-Wed)

- Amazon EventBridge - rules, event patterns, cross-account/cross-region event buses, schedules, Pipes
- AWS Health - events -> EventBridge, organizational view
- Systems Manager OpsCenter / Incident Manager, Automation runbooks
- Automated remediation patterns: EventBridge -> Lambda/SSM Automation/Step Functions

- Troubleshooting - failed deployments, ASG launch failures, CFN errors, CodeDeploy hook failures
- Amazon DevOps Guru

Domain 6 (Thu-Sun)

- IAM - policy evaluation logic, permission boundaries, roles & cross-account access, IAM Identity Center, ABAC, Access Analyzer
- SCPs & RCPs, preventive vs detective controls
- KMS - key policies, grants, multi-region keys, encryption at rest/in transit
- Secrets Manager (rotation) vs Parameter Store SecureString
- Amazon GuardDuty, Amazon Inspector, Amazon Macie, AWS Security Hub, Amazon Detective
- AWS WAF, Shield, Firewall Manager, Network Firewall
- AWS Config + Security Hub for compliance; Audit Manager; Trusted Advisor
- VPC security - security groups, NACLs, VPC endpoints & endpoint policies, PrivateLink

Lab: GuardDuty finding -> EventBridge -> Lambda that isolates an EC2 instance (change SG) + SNS notification.

Checkpoint: Domains 4-6 practice questions (aim >= 70%).

Week 8 - Full Practice Exams (Dec 7 - Dec 13)

- Mon: Full practice exam #1 (timed, 180 min) - score: ____
- Tue: Review every question (right AND wrong); log weak topics below
- Wed: Full practice exam #2 - score: ____
- Thu: Review + re-study weak topics
- Fri: Read AWS whitepapers summaries: *Practicing CI/CD on AWS*, *Blue/Green Deployments on AWS*, *Disaster Recovery of Workloads on AWS*, *Well-Architected - Operational Excellence & Reliability pillars*
- Sat: Full practice exam #3 - score: ____
- Sun: Review + official Skill Builder practice exam

Weak topics log:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Week 9 - Final Review & Exam (Dec 14 - Dec 17)

- Mon: Re-take the lowest-scoring practice exam (aim >= 85%)
- Tue: Rapid review of cheat sheets - deployment strategies, CFN policies, CodeDeploy hooks order, DR strategies, IAM evaluation logic
- Wed: Light review only, rest, check ID & exam logistics
- **Thu, Dec 17: EXAM DAY**

- Buffer: Dec 18-22 if you need to reschedule

Recommended resources

- **Official:** AWS DOP-C02 Exam Guide, AWS Skill Builder (Exam Prep Standard Course + Official Practice Question Set / Practice Exam)
- **Courses:** Stephane Maarek (Udemy) or Adrian Cantrill
- **Practice exams:** Tutorials Dojo (Jon Bonso), Stephane Maarek practice tests
- **Docs/FAQs:** CodeDeploy, CloudFormation, Systems Manager, CloudWatch, EventBridge, Organizations FAQs

Exam-day tips

- Flag long questions and come back; aim for ~2 min per question
- Look for keywords: *least operational overhead*, *most cost-effective*, *fastest recovery*, *without downtime*
- Prefer managed/native AWS services and automation over custom scripts
- Eliminate options that require manual steps when the question asks for automation

Progress tracker

Week	Dates	Focus	Practice score	Done
0	Oct 13-18	Setup & baseline		
1	Oct 19-25	SDLC Automation pt.1		
2	Oct 26-Nov 1	SDLC Automation pt.2		
3	Nov 2-8	IaC		
4	Nov 9-15	Config Mgmt & Multi-Account		
5	Nov 16-22	Resilient Solutions		
6	Nov 23-29	Monitoring & Logging		
7	Nov 30-Dec 6	Incident Response + Security		
8	Dec 7-13	Practice exams		
9	Dec 14-17	Final review + EXAM		